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ARTICLE

The Silence In The Pulpit: When Pastors Stop Preaching On Bible Prophecy

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BY JOE HAWKINS/PROPHECY RECON MARCH 19, 2026

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Across much of the modern church landscape, a curious silence has settled over the pulpit. It is not the silence of reverence or reflection, but the silence of avoidance. Entire portions of Scripture--especially those dealing with the future--are quietly bypassed, rarely explained, and almost never preached through in a systematic way. Topics such as the Rapture, the Tribulation, the Antichrist, the coming Kingdom, and the return of Christ have gradually disappeared from many Sunday morning sermons.

For generations of believers, this silence would have been almost unimaginable. Earlier pastors regularly preached through prophetic books such as Daniel, Ezekiel, Zechariah, and Revelation. Entire sermon series were devoted to the signs of the times and the promises of Christ's return. The expectation of the Lord's coming was not viewed as fringe theology--it was central to the Christian hope.

Today, however, many pastors avoid prophecy altogether.

In some churches, prophetic passages are simply skipped when preaching through books of the Bible. In others, the subject is acknowledged but treated as too controversial or too complicated to address publicly. Still others dismiss prophecy as speculative theology that distracts from what they consider more "practical" aspects of Christian living.

The result is that many believers now sit in churches for years without ever hearing a sermon on the prophetic portions of Scripture.

This shift is significant because prophecy is not a minor theme in the Bible. Scholars often note that roughly one-third of Scripture contains prophetic material. From Genesis to Revelation, God repeatedly reveals His plans for the future. The biblical story moves toward a climactic conclusion in which Christ returns, judges evil, and establishes His kingdom.

Yet in many congregations, this massive portion of God's Word remains largely unexplored.

The silence surrounding prophecy raises an important question: why are so many pastors no longer preaching it?

The answer reveals much about the current condition of the church--and perhaps something about the spiritual climate of the last days.

Why Many Pastors Avoid Prophecy

If such a large portion of the Bible deals with prophecy, why do so many pastors avoid it? The reasons vary from church to church, but several common factors appear repeatedly.

One of the most significant is the fear of controversy. Bible prophecy often involves interpretations that differ among sincere believers. Discussions about the timing of the Rapture, the nature of the Millennium, or the identity of prophetic figures like the Antichrist can quickly become heated debates. In an age when many churches are striving to maintain unity and avoid conflict, some pastors conclude that it is safer simply to avoid the subject altogether.

Rather than risk division within the congregation, they choose to focus on topics they believe will be less controversial.

Another factor is the perceived complexity of prophecy. Books like Daniel, Ezekiel, and Revelation contain symbolic imagery, apocalyptic language, and prophetic timelines that can appear intimidating to both pastors and congregations. Some church leaders feel ill-equipped to explain these passages confidently, especially if they did not receive strong training in prophetic interpretation during their theological education.

As a result, they often default to preaching from passages that feel more straightforward and easier to apply.

There is also the influence of modern church-growth philosophy. In many ministry circles, pastors are encouraged to focus on messages that are immediately practical and relevant to everyday life. Sermons on relationships, finances, emotional health, and personal fulfillment are often seen as more accessible to modern audiences.

Prophecy, by contrast, is sometimes viewed as abstract or speculative--something that may interest theologians but not the average church attendee.

When pastors adopt this mindset, prophetic teaching can gradually disappear from the preaching calendar.

Cultural pressure also plays a role. In an increasingly skeptical and secular society, some church leaders worry that preaching about the end times will make Christianity appear extreme or sensational. Discussions about divine judgment, global upheaval, and the rise of the Antichrist do not fit comfortably within a culture that prefers optimism and stability.

To avoid appearing alarmist or out of touch, some pastors simply choose not to address these topics at all.

Over time, these factors combine to create an environment where prophecy is quietly sidelined. It is not necessarily rejected outright--it is simply ignored. Entire books of Scripture remain unopened, and entire themes of biblical teaching are left unexplored.

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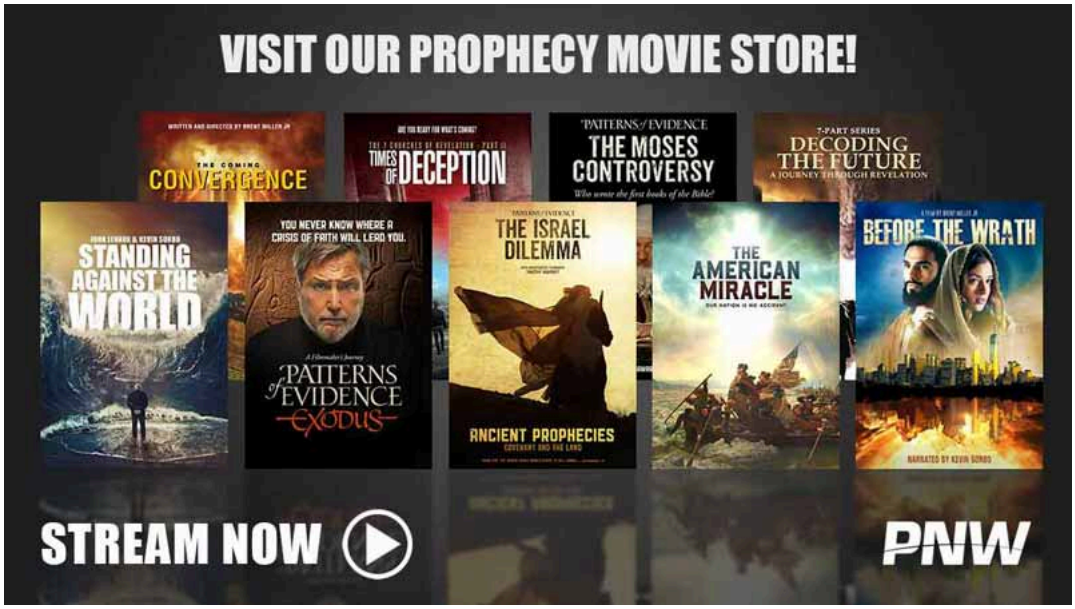

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What Happens When Prophecy Disappears

When prophecy disappears from the pulpit, the consequences reach far beyond the loss of an interesting theological topic. Bible prophecy shapes how believers understand history, culture, and the future. Without it, the church gradually loses its sense of spiritual urgency.

One of the first casualties is the expectation of Christ's return.

For the early church, the promise that Jesus could return at any moment was not a distant theological concept. It was a living hope that shaped daily life. The apostles frequently reminded believers to remain watchful and ready.

Paul wrote to the Thessalonians:

"For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout... and the dead in Christ will rise first." (1 Thessalonians 4:16)
To Titus he described the Christian life as one of anticipation:

"Looking for the blessed hope and the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior, Christ Jesus." (Titus 2:13)
When prophecy is regularly taught, believers are reminded that history is moving toward a divine conclusion. Christ will return. Evil will be judged. God's kingdom will be established.

But when prophecy disappears from preaching, the church slowly loses this forward-looking perspective. Christianity begins to focus almost entirely on the present life rather than the coming kingdom.

Another consequence is the loss of discernment. Prophecy provides a framework for understanding the spiritual and geopolitical movements of the world. It reminds believers that deception, global turmoil, and moral decline are not random developments but realities Scripture warned about long ago.

Jesus Himself cautioned His followers:

"Take heed that no one deceives you." (Matthew 24:4)

Without prophetic teaching, believers may struggle to interpret the signs of the times. Cultural trends, technological changes, and geopolitical events can appear confusing or overwhelming. The prophetic lens that once helped Christians navigate these developments is missing.

The church also loses a powerful motivation for holy living. Throughout the New Testament, the expectation of Christ's return is closely connected to personal holiness.

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perseverance.

When the church forgets that Christ could return at any moment, spiritual complacency often follows. The urgency to live for eternity begins to fade.

In this way, the silence surrounding prophecy does more than leave a gap in biblical teaching. It subtly reshapes the mindset of the church itself.

And that may be one of the most revealing indicators of the spiritual condition of our time.

Prophecy Was Never Meant to Be Optional

One of the greatest misconceptions in the modern church is the idea that Bible prophecy is optional. Some view it as a secondary doctrine--interesting perhaps, but not essential to Christian teaching. Others treat it as a niche subject reserved for theologians or prophecy conferences.

But Scripture presents a very different picture.

From the opening chapters of Genesis to the final pages of Revelation, the Bible unfolds as a prophetic story. God does not merely reveal what has happened in the past or what believers should do in the present. He also reveals what will happen in the future.

Through the prophet Isaiah, the Lord declared:

"Declaring the end from the beginning, and from ancient times things which have not been done, saying, 'My purpose will be established, and I will accomplish all My good pleasure.'" (Isaiah 46:10)
God is not reacting to history--He is directing it. Long before kingdoms rise or fall, before empires appear on the world stage, and before the final chapters of human history unfold, the Lord has already revealed the outcome.

This is one of the unique characteristics of the Bible. No other religious text contains the same level of detailed, predictive prophecy. Throughout Scripture, God repeatedly demonstrated His authority by revealing future events long before they occurred. When those events unfolded exactly as foretold, His Word was vindicated.

The first coming of Jesus Christ provides the clearest example of this. Centuries before His birth, the prophets described the circumstances of the Messiah's arrival. Micah foretold that He would be born in Bethlehem (Micah 5:2). Isaiah described the suffering servant who would bear the sins of many (Isaiah 53). Zechariah predicted that the Messiah would enter Jerusalem riding on a donkey (Zechariah 9:9) and that He would be betrayed for thirty pieces of silver (Zechariah 11:12-13).

These were not vague predictions. They were precise declarations that came to pass exactly as God had spoken.

The life, death, and resurrection of Jesus fulfilled dozens of prophecies written centuries earlier. From His birthplace to His crucifixion, the events of the Gospel unfolded according to the prophetic Scriptures. This pattern establishes an important principle: if the prophecies concerning Christ's first coming were fulfilled literally and precisely, there is every reason to expect that the prophecies concerning His second coming will be fulfilled in the same way.

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Antichrist, the judgment of the nations, and the establishment of Christ's kingdom.

To treat those passages as optional is to overlook a significant portion of God's revealed Word.

Even more striking is the fact that Jesus Himself spoke frequently about the future. Entire sections of the Gospels are devoted to His prophetic teaching. In the Olivet Discourse, recorded in Matthew 24-25, Mark 13, and Luke 21, Jesus described the conditions that would characterize the last days. He warned of deception, wars, earthquakes, persecution, and global upheaval. He spoke of the coming Tribulation and of His visible return to the earth in power and glory.

These were not obscure or incidental remarks. They were central elements of His teaching.

In fact, Jesus often connected prophecy directly to the spiritual readiness of His followers. Over and over again He urged believers to remain watchful and prepared.

"Therefore be on the alert, for you do not know which day your Lord is coming." (Matthew 24:42)
The apostles carried this same emphasis into their teaching. Paul described believers as those who are "looking for the blessed hope and the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior, Christ Jesus" (Titus 2:13). Peter urged believers to live holy and godly lives as they anticipate "the coming of the day of God" (2 Peter 3:12).

Even the final book of the Bible opens with a remarkable promise concerning prophecy itself:

"Blessed is he who reads and those who hear the words of the prophecy, and heed the things which are written in it; for the time is near." (Revelation 1:3)
Notice that the blessing is not limited to scholars or theologians. It is given to those who read it, hear it, and take it seriously.

In other words, God never intended prophecy to remain hidden in the background of church life. It was meant to be proclaimed, understood, and embraced by believers.

When pastors avoid preaching prophetic passages, they are not merely skipping over a few difficult verses. They are leaving unexplored a significant portion of the biblical narrative. The grand story of redemption moves toward a future climax when Christ returns to judge evil and establish His kingdom.

Without prophecy, that story feels incomplete.

The church is left with a gospel that looks backward to the cross but rarely looks forward to the crown. Yet the full message of Scripture points to both. The same Savior who came once in humility will come again in glory.

Prophecy reminds believers that history is not spiraling out of control. It is moving toward the fulfillment of God's plan.

And for that reason, prophecy was never meant to be optional. It is woven into the very fabric of Scripture itself--and it remains one of the clearest reminders that the God who spoke in the past will also bring His promises for the future to pass.

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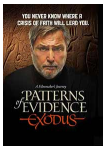

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